shown by the US in being a champion of democracy on one hand and supporting dictatorships on the other. The frank reply was revealing indeed – 'our national interests will always predominate while deciding foreign policy, double standards notwithstanding.' This was realpolitik! We were then taken to California, where we were briefed at the headquarters of the US Army National Guard. We returned via Tokyo, so it virtually turned out to be a trip where we went round the globe. A great experience, indeed.

On graduating from the NDC in December 1993, I was posted as the deputy director general of operational logistics (DDGOL) in the Army HQ. This was my first assignment in Delhi since my commissioning in 1964! For no fault of mine, I had been denied the experience of serving in the 'mad house', as the Army HQ is jocularly referred to, and widening my horizons. Despite my high profile and sound professional track record, I never got a Delhi posting for the first thirty years of my service in the army. This was because there is a category of officers in every army of the world, and I would prefer to call them 'parasites'. We have them, too. These selfish specimens of humanity neither care for others, nor for the good of the army. They repeatedly wangle their way and get plum postings at Delhi or other sought-after stations like Pune, Chandigarh or Kolkata, while the straightforward guys have to grind their arses in unattractive places like Binnaguri, Tibri, Talbehat or Danapur, or in remote field areas, and bear more than their share of the hardships. This situation is mainly attributable to such officers.

The exposure at the Army HQ at the level of a brigadier was an eyeopener. Since I had never served in a staff appointment above a Divisional HQ before, there was a lot of bureaucratese that I was clueless about. My boss, Major General Samay Ram, was a highly decorated and experienced soldier, a veteran of the low-intensity conflict that we had engaged in against the LTTE in Sri Lanka in the late 1980s. We had never served together before. In fact, we met for the first time when I reported on duty at the Army HQ in January 1994. Both of us were forthright and practical but with different backgrounds and operational experiences, and hence, quite often we did not see eye to eye. I have always found it difficult to impress